

Camera. The need for a higher-resolution camera mounted on the drone gradually increases as you shift from being a beginner to a professional. At the entry level, a 2MP HD camera with 4K resolution is a good enough option. However, it is the gimbal and anti-shake features that determine stability of the footage. Gimbals come in 3- and 2-axis, and 3-axis does a better job of film-making and photography.

First-person vision. This is simply video plotting on a screen that is used to pilot drones. Some drones have a screen mounted on the remote control. Head-mounted first-person vision can give you a more immersive experience of piloting a drone, but it can be expensive.

Major drones in the market

Beginner-level drones. Blade Pico drones are equipped with a sensor called sensor-assisted flight envelope (SAFE), which helps it understand if the flight attained is stable, and if not, it stabilises itself. For beginners, this is a great buy as the drone does not spin off and crash. It works at 2.4GHz frequency, has a 6-axis gyro and weighs about 200 grams with a sustainable flight of seven minutes.

Drones from Hubsan have durable build and come with detachable propeller guards to protect the propellers from breaking in case of crash. These come with one-click flip in forward and backward directions; these level themselves in mid-flight, if these sense no human control. These weigh around 340 grams—a little heavier than Blade—while giving up to nine minutes of flight and a control distance of over 100 metres.

Intermediate-level drones.

Drones from UDI are designed to be wind-resistant so that these can work in rough outdoor conditions. Falling under intermediate segment, a UDI drone houses an HD camera of up to 720-pixel resolution for better visual recordings and a microSD card slot. It comes with an LCD display that

shows the vitals of the drone such as battery power for sustained flight, areas for safe landings and one-key return to bring the drone back to its original take-off site.

With cameras capable of delivering up to 1080-pixel video quality, Syma drone would be a winner in terms of cost and agility. Its frame is sturdy and light, giving 10 to 12 minutes of flight time for extended videography or photography. Capture videos in a 360-degree ever-sion (inside-out movement) and all you will see is key metrics on the LCD screen.

Professional-level drones.

Drones from Parrot can be regarded as ariel gymnasts. Parrots are designed for speed, and almost all drones in the segment are fast enough to handle speeds up to 18 kilometres an hour. These link up easily to Android or iOS smartphones. Pressure sensors and altimeters, in addition to ultrasound sensors and accelerometers, are integrated for evaluating safer zones to fly in their flight path. These have far greater flash memory storage. Applications to control the drones are immersive enough to ignore the remote control.

If you want a drone with vision sensors, a long range of about 4.3 kilometres, real-time first-person vision on the smartphone, virtual joystick, satellites connectivity for location locking and auto-return by itself, your search would end with a futuristically-designed drone from UTI. This drone, small enough to fit in your backpack or pocket, demonstrates intelligent flight modes once you unwrap it and switch it on.

Perfect for hi-definition videography, the UTI drone has flow-mode setting that automatically locks on the object it is looking at and follows it intelligently through an ascend or descend, while it captures vision in 2.7k resolution. With a control distance of one kilometre, this is one drone that packs the punch. **EFY**

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